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Power Tips for for using a Laptop Computer

■ **Laptops are Unergonomic:** Laptop design violates a basic ergonomic requirement for a computer, namely that the keyboard and screen should be separate. The reason is simple—in a fixed design, if the keyboard is in an optimal position for the user, the screen isn't and if the screen is, then the keyboard isn't. This means that you need to pay special attention to how you use your laptop because it can cause you problems. Consider purchasing a separate keyboard.

■ **Laptop Posture:** As indicated above, laptops violate basic ergonomic design requirements, so using a laptop is a trade-off between poor neck and head posture, and poor hand or wrist posture.

■ **Occasional Users:** Because the neck and head position is determined by the actions of large muscles, you are better off sacrificing neck posture rather than wrist posture. Find a comfortable chair, position your laptop on your lap and angle the

screen such that you can do not strain your body

■ **Full-time Users:** If you use your laptop at work as your main computer you should position this on your desk/work surface in front of you so that you can see the screen without bending your neck. Use a separate keyboard and mouse. Use the keyboard on a negative-tilt keyboard tray to ensure a wrist neutral posture. Use the mouse on an adjustable position mouse platform.

■ **Laptop Dimensions:** Many laptops offer large screens and can work as desktop replacements. The larger the screen the more difficult it will be to use this in mobile locations (e.g. airplane, car, train).

■ **Laptop Weight:** If you are a mobile professional, think about the weight of the system. By the word 'system' we mean the weight of the laptop plus all its accessories. Many lightweight portables can become as heavy as regular laptops when you add the weight of all of the components.



The Future of Laptops

PDAs will be capable of handling full motion (30 fps) video as easily as they would handle gaming and 3G communication. Devices such as the HP iPAQ H3950, Pocket LOOX 600, Toshiba Genio E550G and O2 XDA, based on newer processors such as Intel's XScale chips are enhancing mobile computing power.

The XScale processors are available in two variants—the PXA250 (400 MHz, 300 MHz and 200 MHz) and the PXA210 (200 MHz and 133 MHz). They consume up to one-third of the power of their predecessors, the Strong ARM processors. The PXA250 is aimed at handheld laptops, while the PXA210 is tailored for entry-level handhelds and cell phones. These processors also incorporate advanced power management features.

By integrating memory and LCD controllers onto the chip itself, they reduce the number of components in the handhelds they are used in. Both these processors come with 64 KB of cache and feature Intel's Integrated Performance Primitives (IPP), which provides in-built functions for signal processing (for speech and handwriting recognition), MP3 codecs,

MPEG-4 and H.263 video-conferencing codes. They also feature Windows CE .Net support.

Besides these processors, there are a slew of other devices, like the Handspring Treo 270 based on the 33 MHz Dragonball VZ processor, and the HP Jornada 928, based on the 133 MHz TI OMAP710 processor. All these enhancements indicate that the new super-breed of handhelds will enable users to run applications that were never thought possible, at speeds never experienced before.

As for future laptops, they will have faster microprocessors with more memory. The storage devices may change

from removable disks (Floppy, Zip, CD, and DVD) to solid state memory, which could make them even lighter and thinner. While some models of laptops already have the ability to send and receive data using infrared and wireless Internet technologies, this feature may become more common.

In the more distant future, regular laptops may even eventually be replaced by wearable computers.

